TECHOPS HERO

VOLUME XIII

# THE LAST LAUNCH

MIKE OLIVARES

VOLUME XIII

# The Last Launch

Chapters 29–34 • 38 illustrated story pages


29 **The count after** 1

30 **What the station held** 5

31 **The route they left** 9

32 **What survived the file** 17

33 **A table for four** 21

34 **The names we carry** 29

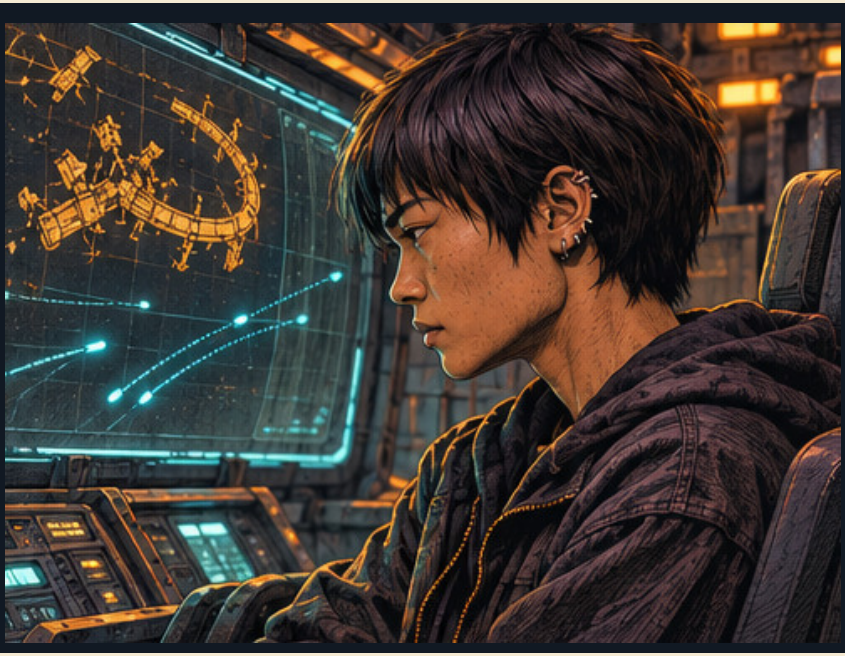

Sector 4 has fallen. The ships are still answering.

Tap a chapter to open it.

## 29 / THE COUNT AFTER

Sector 4 orbit • after the strike

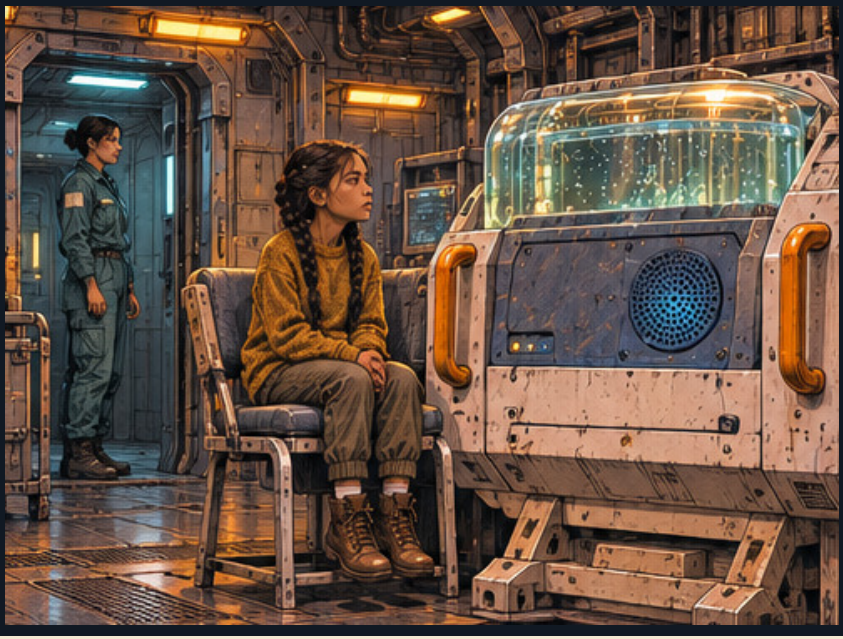
The detention station has gone quiet. The ships are still answering.



**IONA** Medical One. Start with the people who need power.

## 29 / THE COUNT AFTER

Medical One • same watch



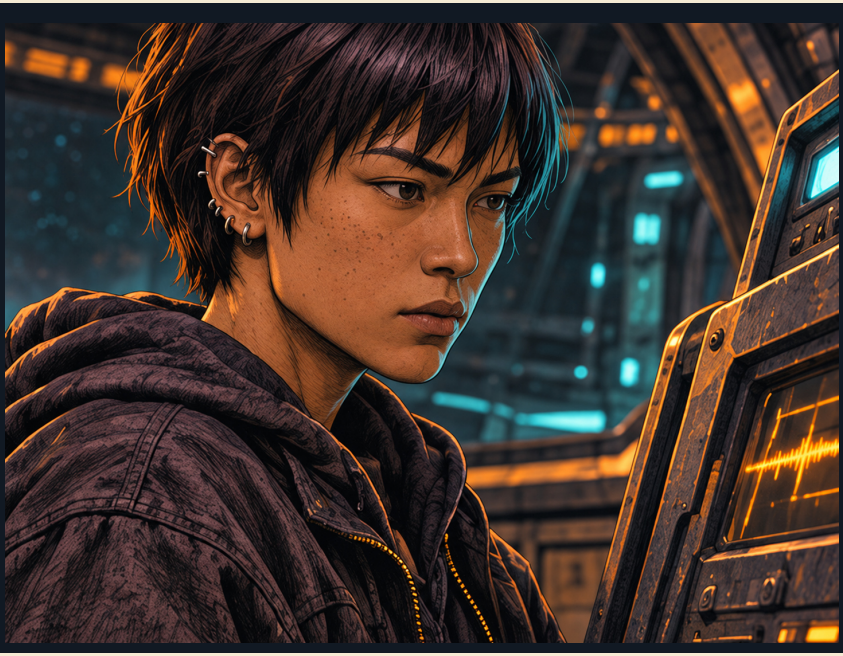
**MEDIC** Independent power holds. The ward is at temperature.

**LUZ** Dad?
**TOMAS, SPEAKER** Here. Tell them I can hear.

## 29 / THE COUNT AFTER

Sector 4 orbit • evacuation roll call

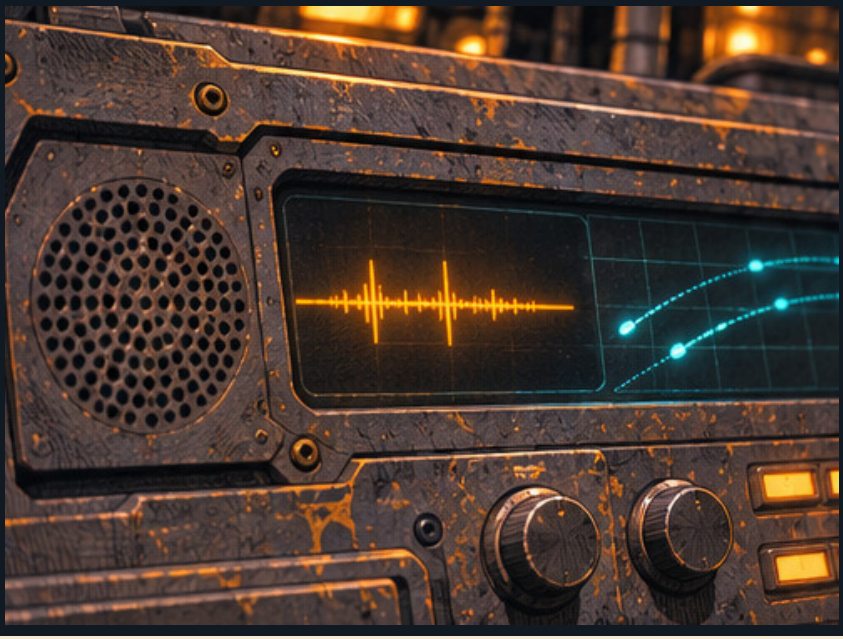
A stretcher on the freight ship is empty. Its patient was moved to Medical One.



**IONA** Read that transfer back to me. Then have someone on both ships sign it.

## 29 / THE COUNT AFTER

Iona's bridge • a saved exchange



BEFORE THE STRIKE • IONA: Are you down?
K: I made it back. I'm on Earth.

She saves the exchange locally. The open channel is for the ships still leaving.

## 30 / WHAT THE STATION HELD

Earth • after Ghost Fork

K sits through a whole cup going cold. Iona's last reply stays saved on the receiver.

**MIKE** Want company?
**K** Sit for a minute.

## 30 / WHAT THE STATION HELD

Earth • Mike's kitchen

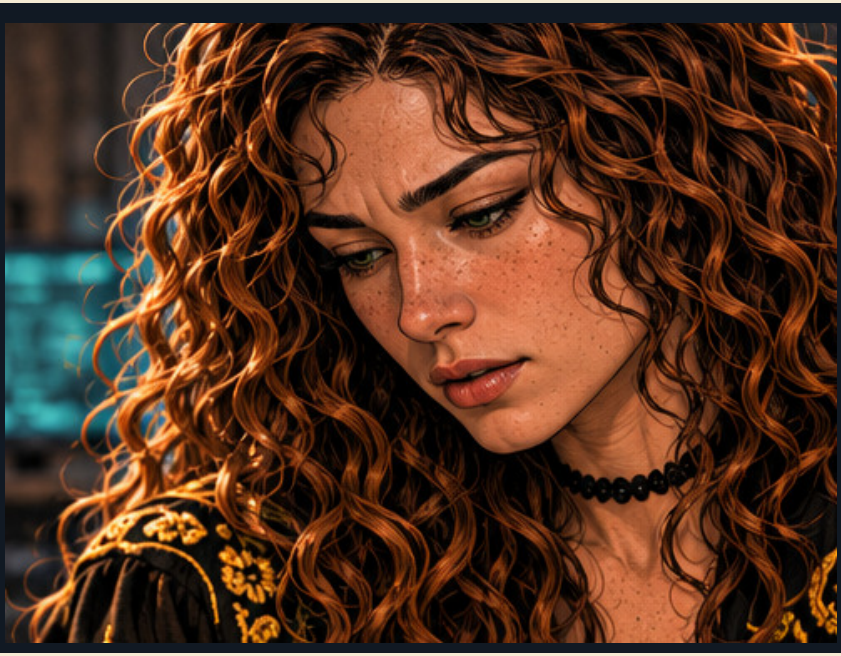
**K** You know Sector Four?
**MIKE** The site code. I know some of the equipment.

**K** I was in Cell 118. Can I tell you what happened before you look anything up?

## 30 / WHAT THE STATION HELD

Earth • later that day

K describes intake once. Felicia compares his sequence with a copy she kept before they met.



**FELICIA** That's the same acceptance test. I couldn't tell what it was testing until now.

## 30 / WHAT THE STATION HELD

Earth • archived service records

Mike opens an Earth-side restart log. His access reaches the host records. The custody details are absent.

**MIKE** I can show you what came back online.
**K** I can tell you what it felt like on the other side.

## 31 / THE ROUTE THEY LEFT

Medical One • after the strike

**MEDIC** Two accounts for one cradle. AeroTech's sheet still has him in the rack.

**IONA, RADIO** Put his name in the passenger book. Have him confirm it.

## 31 / THE ROUTE THEY LEFT

Escort • clearing the last debris

The escort leaves last. The gun stays cold. One of the cargo ships takes its place beside the medical transport.

**PILOT** We can spare a tow line.
**IONA, RADIO** Bring it around slow.

## 31 / THE ROUTE THEY LEFT

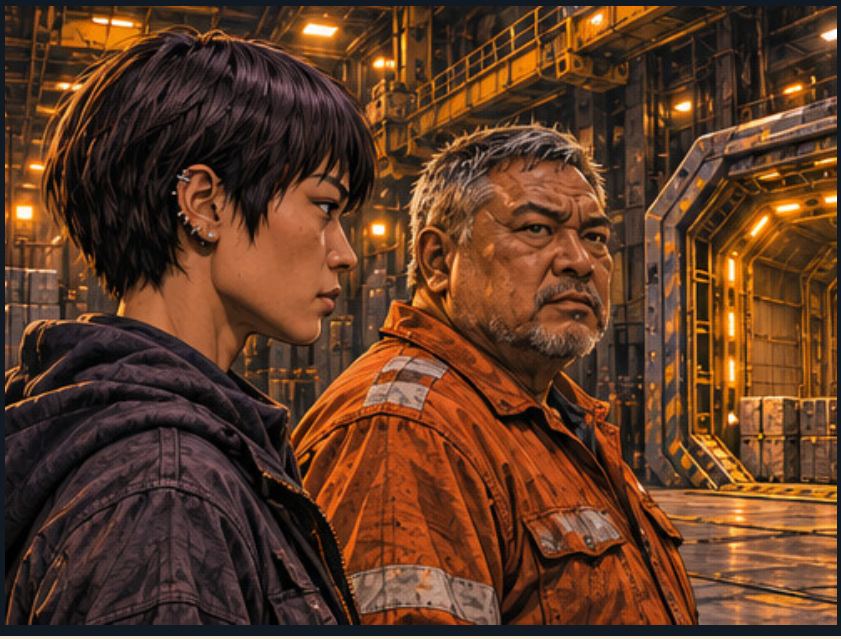
Iona's bridge • retained records

The original freight bay. The dogs' impact damaged the berth and triggered a recovery order.

Iona lays the new work order alongside the old incident image. The bay and the custody system have separate approvals.

## 31 / THE ROUTE THEY LEFT

Earlier • Sector 4 freight recovery



**DOCK CHIEF** My work order gets us into this bay. The inner door still belongs to custody.

The reader rejects her at the next door. Iona had counted on needing a second way.

## 31 / THE ROUTE THEY LEFT

Earlier • the workshop

They have a service transport and a copy of its route. The return leg goes to AeroTech's fleet depot.

**MARA** You still need a second medical pilot.
**IONA** Ask the one whose license they pulled.

## 31 / THE ROUTE THEY LEFT

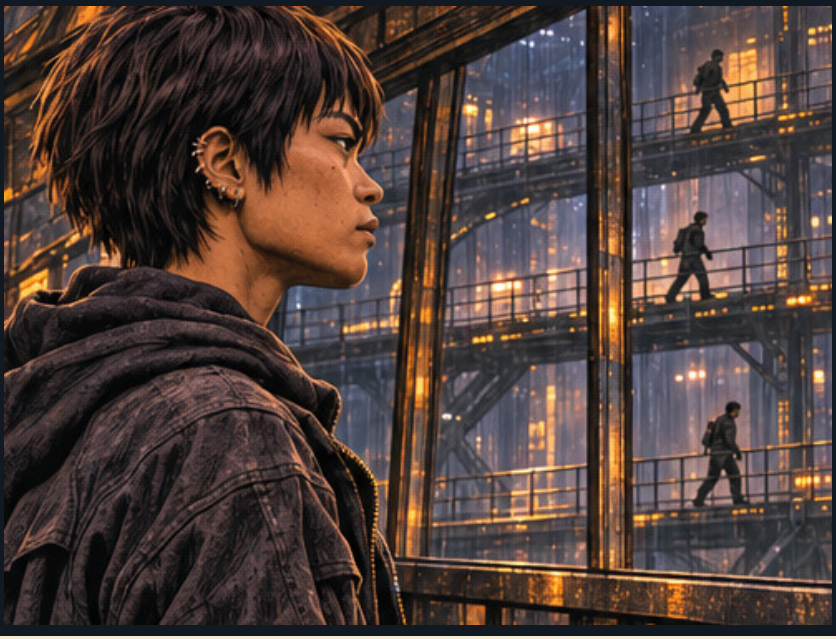
Earlier • AeroTech fleet depot

The service crew comes back with the ship AeroTech sent. Their return clearance gets them to the recovery berth.

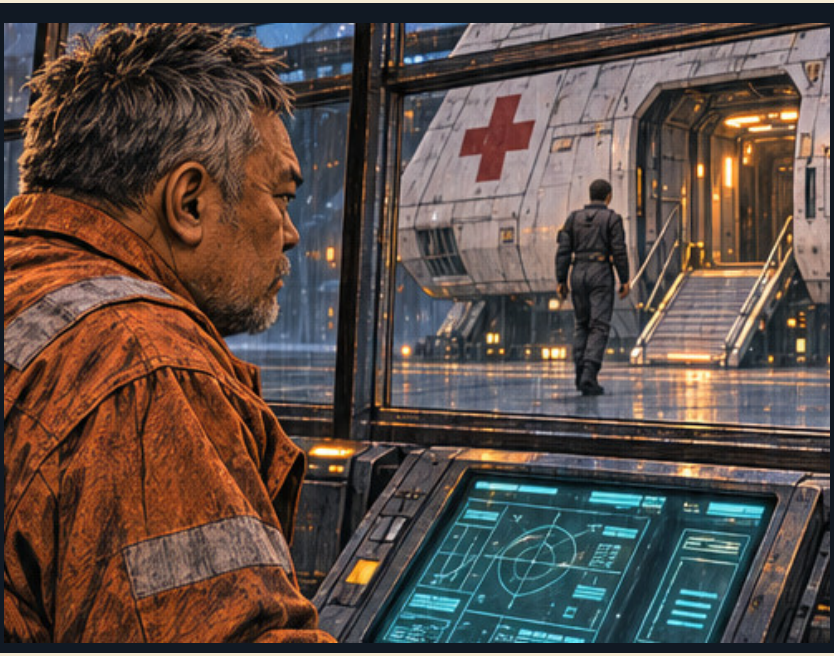
Across the glass: two medical ships on standby and an escort awaiting crews. The maintenance team is already aboard.

## 31 / THE ROUTE THEY LEFT

Earlier • the depot launch gallery



**IONA** Three pilots. Three local release stations. We only get one change of shift.



The dock chief keeps the readiness launch on the schedule. Iona's pilots board as maintenance relief.

## 31 / THE ROUTE THEY LEFT

Earlier • launch clearance

The dock grants the readiness launch it expected. Once clear, the relief pilots take local control and peel away together.

**MEDICAL TWO, RADIO** I've got the second ship.
**IONA** Copy. Tell me what your ward can carry.

Her grandfather encrypts the rehearsal time and the name of the song he wants to hear.

**FELICIA** You hid the answer under the teapot.
**GRANDFATHER** And you found it.

## 32 / WHAT SURVIVED THE FILE

Earlier • rehearsal

**DRUMMER** Leave a bar before you come back in.
**FELICIA** All right. From the top.

She listens through the silence. Then she takes the job she thinks will let her build things worth protecting.

## 32 / WHAT SURVIVED THE FILE

Earlier • Felicia's independent audit

A participant withdrew. The record was corrected. Training on the same subject was still billed the next month.

The exception gets a new heading. Felicia keeps the original, the revision, and the invoice.

## 32 / WHAT SURVIVED THE FILE

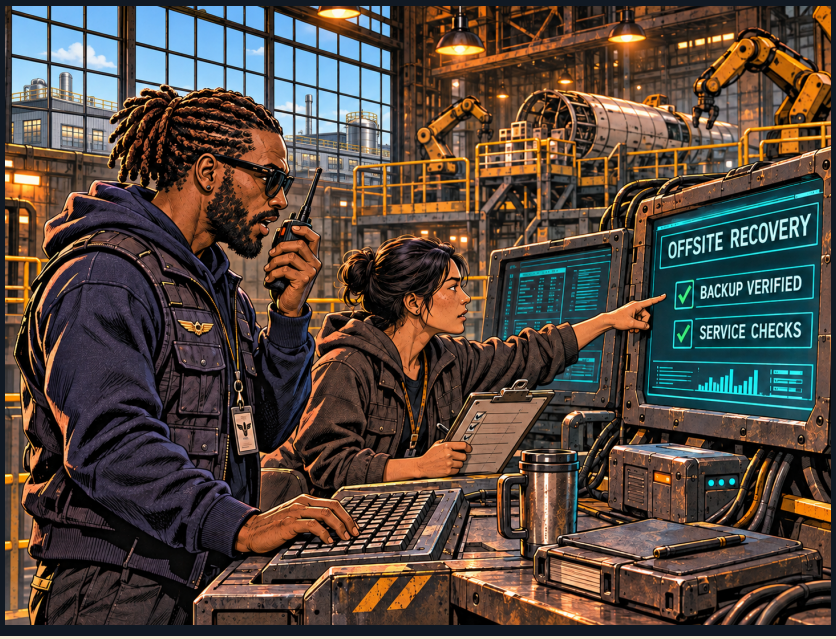
Earth - after Sector 4 falls

**FELICIA, TO SOC** Sector 4's power and links died together. Treat it as site loss. Preserve the last telemetry and fence those routes before failover.

His tablet sounds on the factory floor: **SECTOR 4 LOST.**
**MIKE, RADIO** Declare a major incident. Start disaster recovery.

## 32 / WHAT SURVIVED THE FILE

Earth - disaster recovery; later, the retained receipt



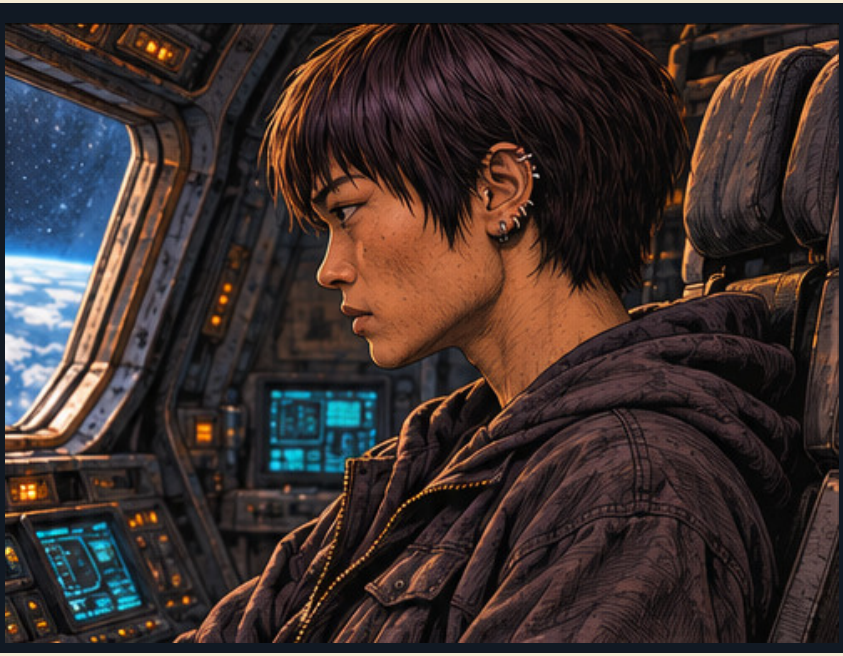

**MIKE** Isolate Sector 4. Restore Earth-side services from the verified offsite backup. Keep the line held until service checks pass.

**FELICIA** This post-strike receipt matches another installation.
**MIKE** Keep the raw one. We'll see which others answer.

## 33 / A TABLE FOR FOUR

Six months after the strike • Earth approach

Iona's stolen research transport makes the ordinary crossing. On approach, she waits for a berth.



One of the medical ships is already in. Iona waits until a named person acknowledges the handoff.

## 33 / A TABLE FOR FOUR

Earth • after the voice window in Chapter 28

The next message comes on a quiet afternoon. Iona names a café and gives K a choice of two times.

K replies with the earlier time. He puts the receiver down before it can light up again.

## 33 / A TABLE FOR FOUR

Earth • the café

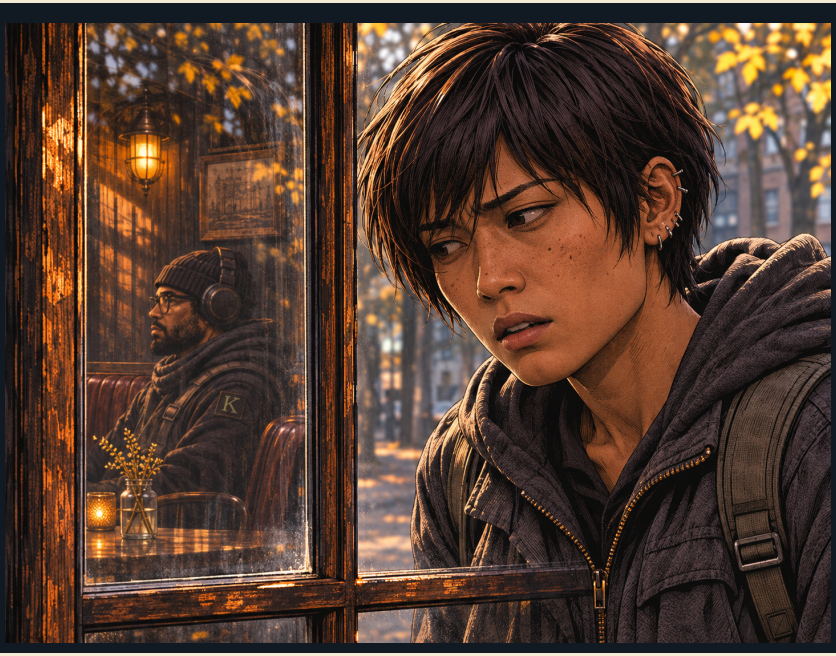
K gets there early. He takes the seat with the wall behind him and the door in view.

Iona sees him through the window. She stops long enough for a passerby to move between them.

## 33 / A TABLE FOR FOUR

Iona remembers - Low Quarter / back at the cafe

**IONA, REMEMBERED** One. Two. Three. Four.
Red's guitar came in exactly where she expected.



**IONA, THOUGHT** That's his stillness. But why does he look so different?

## 33 / A TABLE FOR FOUR

Earth • the café

**IONA** Still take it sweet?
**K** I don't know what I used to do. What did I order?

**IONA** Enough sugar to ruin it.
**K** Leave one packet. We'll start there.

## 33 / A TABLE FOR FOUR

Earth • the café

The first cup cools. For a minute they talk about how good it feels to hear a voice across a table.

**K** I can remember a sound and still get the room wrong.
**IONA** We can talk about this room.

## 33 / A TABLE FOR FOUR

Earth • Mike's place

**FELICIA** His check-in put him across town. Did he tell you he was going out?

**MIKE** No. He usually calls if he's going somewhere public.

## 33 / A TABLE FOR FOUR

Earth • outside the café

Felicia spots K through the glass. Mike sees a second cup and pauses at the door.

**FELICIA** We could call.
**MIKE** We came this far.

## 33 / A TABLE FOR FOUR

Earth - the interruption

**IONA** Wait... who are you? How do you know him?
**MIKE** Mike. K's staying with me.
**K** You didn't happen to be here.

Mike's badge swings into view when he pulls out a chair. Iona reads it before she looks up at him.

**IONA** You've been in the mouth of the beast this whole time.
**K** He gave me somewhere to stay.

**IONA** You let me think I knew who I was coming to see.

## 34 / THE NAMES WE CARRY

Earth • the café

**FELICIA** I worked on the research transfer safeguards. That's how I found the—

**IONA** Cruz. Your name was on the screen when we tried to move him.

Iona's chair goes back hard. One cup hits the floor.

**IONA** His daughter was standing there. Our ship could keep him alive. Your screen still said no.

## 34 / THE NAMES WE CARRY

Earth • the café

**FELICIA** I wrote the life-support check. I need to see what they put around it.

**K** Iona. Sit or come outside with me. Give her room to answer.

Felicia waits for Iona to look at her.
**FELICIA** What's his name?

**IONA** Tomas. His daughter is Luz. They both made it.

Earth • outside the café

**K** I'm walking with her. I'll call when I'm ready.
**MIKE** Okay.

**K** We need to talk about who can see where I am.
**MIKE** We will.

## 34 / THE NAMES WE CARRY

Earth • later

Felicia writes the names beside a printout of her own safeguard. She leaves space for their account of what happened.

She leaves the AeroTech form to one side and starts with a blank sheet.

## 34 / THE NAMES WE CARRY

Earth • a quiet walk

**IONA** Want to hear what he said the first time his daughter found him?
**K** Tell me.

They walk on. The next conversation is theirs.